

Research Ethics in HCI: A SIGCHI Community Discussion

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ABSTRACT

An ongoing challenge within the HCI community is coming to a shared understanding of research ethics in the face of our diverse disciplinary traditions, evolving technologies and methods, and multiple geographic and cultural settings. Building upon previous panels and town halls organized by the SIGCHI Research Ethics Committee at conferences including CSCW, CHI, GROUP, and IDC, this special interest group convening is intended to provide space for the broader HCI community to highlight, debate, and discuss current ethical challenges within our domain, and work toward the development of guidelines and processes for supporting—and evaluating—ethical research. For 2022, we are proposing a SIG rather than a more formal panel, to encourage more people who are not committee members to speak, share, and discuss their perspectives and challenges when engaging with research ethics in HCI. This conversation will benefit from a diversity of voices and perspectives to help us all learn from each other and think deeply and the values and ethical commitments of our research community.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Social and professional topics;

KEYWORDS

hci, ethics, research ethics, research methods

ACM Reference Format:

Casey Fiesler, Christopher Frauenberger, Michael Muller, Jessica Vitak, and Michael Zimmer. 2022. Research Ethics in HCI: A SIGCHI Community Discussion. In *CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems Extended Abstracts (CHI '22 Extended Abstracts)*, April 29-May 5, 2022, New Orleans, LA, USA. ACM, New York, NY, USA, 3 pages. <https://doi.org/10.1145/3491101.3516400>

1 INTRODUCTION

An ongoing challenge within the diverse HCI community is coming to a shared understanding of research ethics in the face of our diverse disciplinary traditions, evolving technology and methods, and the growing diversity of standards across institutions, government

and industry settings, and regional and national cultures. Novel and persisting open questions for research ethics in recent years have prompted numerous discussions within our community, including but not limited to the paper reviewing process. Since 2016, the SIGCHI Research Ethics Committee has been in place to advise SIGCHI conferences and communities on ethical issues that arise in the course of our research. The committee has held panels at a number of conferences, including CSCW, CHI, GROUP, and IDC [2, 4–7, 10, 11, 15], but it is critical to have more open and interactive discussions with the broader HCI community that involves a diversity of perspectives and stakeholders. As such, the purpose of this SIG is to launch this broader discussion, with the Research Ethics Committee serving a supporting role.

Research ethics presents challenges across multiple aspects of the HCI community, including how we learn about ethics (what kind of training should new researchers receive, and how do we ensure existing researchers keep up?), how we engage in ethical research methods (what are best practices around data collection, consent, data sharing, etc?), and how we evaluate research (how should ethics be part of paper review and consideration for awards?). However, because ours is such an interdisciplinary and global community, best practices around research ethics remain elusive. Still, based on years of data from these processes as well as conversations from previous panels, the Research Ethics Committee is well positioned to help move the SIGCHI community towards a broader discussion of what kind of shared ethical standards and principles might be possible. For example, the most recent panel held by the committee at CSCW 2021 [6] listed a number of example topics that have been raised at various points during the committee's existence:

- What special precautions should we take when researching vulnerable populations or stigmatized or minoritized groups or issues?
- What are best practices for research that uses data created by humans (e.g., social media posts) that does not constitute human subjects research under typical legal definitions? For example, are there risks in reporting direct quotes from public data or in creating an archive of content outside of its original context? Are there ethical issues with researchers violating terms of service?
- How can researchers from a socially empowered culture do ethical research that involves members of a different, less socially-empowered culture?
- Who speaks on behalf of whom? What are the ethics of writing about someone else's situation? How do these ethics shift

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CHI '22 Extended Abstracts, April 29-May 5, 2022, New Orleans, LA, USA

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ACM ISBN 978-1-4503-9156-6/22/04.

<https://doi.org/10.1145/3491101.3516400>

with different degrees of power between “researchers” and “researched”? Under what circumstances does a researcher have a duty to report what they have learned? Under what circumstances does a researcher have a duty to refrain from reporting? Who decides?

- What is the meaning of “consent,” and how should consent be obtained, from members of groups, cultures, or nations that for historical reasons now distrust researchers from mainstream or empowered groups?
- Who gives consent for whom - when the primary research participant is an adult? a child? a member of an individualist culture? a member of a collectivist culture?
- How can we manage the balance of anticipatory ethics and in-action / situated ethics when much work in the CHI community has exploratory character and outcomes and processes are not entirely in researchers’ hands?
- When should positionality statements be part of research publications and reviews, and can such statements be harmful as well as helpful?
- Should there be consent practices for online experiments conducted by platforms and/or where people are not informed about their participation? What are the proper ethical considerations for conducting and then debriefing from studies that involve deception?
- In light of increasing calls for greater transparency, data sharing, and open science within HCI, how do we balance this important value with privacy and research ethics for the humans and the communities represented in our data? How does this balance shift with different degrees of power between “researchers” and “researched”?
- How well do current ethics guidelines (e.g. Respect for Persons, Justice) help researchers think about the unintended consequences of their work, and in particular the ways that unintended consequences of research, design and technology tend to apply unequally? And are these the right guidelines and ways of thinking about research ethics for our community?
- Can we engage in or formulate strategies for “after-care”, in our efforts to mitigate negative consequences of unintended use of our outcomes - as in “staying with the trouble”?

A Twitter thread¹ about topics raised at the CHI 2019 panel covered a number of additional topics that were raised by community members: conflicts of interest in industry research; best practice for research that engages with disability; how to engage ethically with the political consequences of the work that we do; caring for researchers conducting work on upsetting or triggering topics; the relationship between ethics and justice in our research practices; and planning for contingencies when conducting research with vulnerable participants.

Both of these town hall style panels also prompted community members to raise questions and offer thoughts about process and the role of the committee. For example, while the committee provides advice to program committees when ethical issues come up during the review process, how might HCI researchers get more help at the right time—before the research is conducted and submitted

for review? Additionally, despite the challenge that ethical values vary across geographic location, culture, and sub-disciplines, is it possible to create ethical standards for the CHI community? There are also ongoing discussions about whether the CHI community should be more purposefully writing about the possible negative consequences of research [12], including whether SIGCHI venues should consider adopting a requirement similar to NeurIPS broader impact statements [16]. We feel that it is important that these kinds of processes are built from the broader community itself, and that this SIG will help cultivate those conversations.

2 STRUCTURE AND FORMAT

Based on the experience and knowledge of community issues from the SIGCHI Research Ethics Committee as described above, as well as information and questions gathered from community members prior to the conference, the committee will introduce basic information about processes and common issues regarding research ethics in our community. At the start of the SIG, we will also solicit anonymous questions, thoughts, and examples of ethical issues they have encountered to be part of the broader discussion. Following this introduction, we will move to open discussion that will be organized based on themes that came up in the online discussion plus on-the-fly affinity grouping of what appears on notecards or questions asked openly. We will also introduce guidelines for respectful discussion. Importantly, as this is not a panel, our hope is that most questions will not be addressed to the committee, but rather framed towards the entire group, to be answered with multiple perspectives and even debated.

Beyond this open discussion, we will also have pre-prepared case studies that bring up common issues that have arisen during SIGCHI review processes over the years. We will ask participants to discuss these case studies in small groups and to consider best practices, open questions, and challenges; these discussion might suggest resolutions to the case study or sharpen the issue into a critical question for discussion.

3 CULTIVATING AND MAINTAINING A COMMUNITY

For this SIG, we will draw in conversations from both this body of knowledge and from the broader community—for example, ethics-related workshops [1, 8, 14, 17–19], panels [2, 4–7, 9–11, 15], and previous SIGs [3, 13] held at SIGCHI conferences over the past decade. Additionally, in order to cultivate an even broader conversation among the SIGCHI community than with those who can attend CHI, several prior to the conference we will engage via social media (e.g., the committee’s Facebook group, the CHI Meta Facebook group, Twitter, and the SIGCHI Discord server) and collect questions and topics of interest both openly and via an anonymous form.

Our hope is that this SIG will attract community members who are already deeply interested in thinking about research ethics generally, those who have been thinking about issues relevant to their own work, and those who might be new to much of these topics. We welcome anyone within the broader HCI community, including students just embarking on their research agenda and senior

¹<https://twitter.com/cfiesler/status/112568084284246544>

scholars ready to share their experience. We anticipate both academic researchers and industry practitioners will be interested as ethics has become a pervasive challenge throughout the HCI community regardless of one's position. We particularly seek insights from members who work in sensitive contexts or with vulnerable populations where research ethics is a prime concern.

Following the SIG, we will report back to the broader community via social media and a blog post (ideally to be posted to the SIGCHI blog). Importantly, we will also request that the participants in the SIG continue these discussions—both at the conference and at their home institution—and we will solicit suggestions for how to best continue year-long conversations virtually. Our goal is for this SIG to spark the creation of a community of practice that is much larger than our committee.

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